

excuse (a little white lie) like “Oh, the kids kept messing with it so it’s up in my bedroom.”

3. Beware of the previously regifted gift.

Sometimes you’ll receive a gift that doesn’t quite feel right. Your Spidey Sense will tingle and you’ll realize, perhaps after some investigation, that this gift has already been through the regifting process. Now you’ve got problems. The last thing you want is for the gift to end up back in the hands of the person who originally gave it; not only will you look embarrassed, but so will the person who gave it to you. And we don’t want friendships strained. My best advice: If in doubt, regifting is out.

4. Keep tabs on the gifts and the people who gave them.

When you receive a gift that is destined to be a gift once again, label it as soon as you can with the name of the person who gave it to you, and when they gave it to you. This is a simple habit to get into, but an essential one for regifting. Post-it Notes are okay; although if they fall off you’re relying on your memory. I would suggest something a little stronger, maybe a

Post-it in combination with an elastic band. Don’t use strong tape on something that will rip or tear the gift or packaging. If you want, you could use a small notebook instead. Log items in the same way you would to write thank-you cards for wedding presents and baby shower gifts.

5. Keep everything in the original packaging.

Keep all the original packaging, including instructions, twisty-ties and anything else that accompanied the gift to keep it in that *new* condition. Even if you’ve never used it, a coffee machine or spanky-new DVD player is less impressive when the instructions are missing and it’s rattling around inside the box. You can get away with packaging loss on some items, such as ornaments, photo frames, and so forth. But generally, if the packaging has gone bye-bye, so has your chance of regifting the item.

6. Some items are bad regifting choices.

Some people say candles fall into this category, but I’d have to disagree. For a start, they can make up part of a larger gift, especially a gift basket. And some people genuinely like candles; if you know one of those people,